

Newborough Warren

Weather & Water Watch

April 2026

Weather Summary

Metric	Newborough (IBODOR6)	RAF Valley	Typical April*
Total Rainfall	49.8 mm	29.8 mm	~54.4 mm
Average Highs		14.4°C	12.1°C
Average Lows		6.5°C	6.1°C
Sunshine		243.9 hrs	172.9 hrs
Air Frost		0 days	~0.5 days

**Based on 1991–2020 Met Office climate averages (RAF Valley). Local gauge: IBODOR6 (Weather Underground).*

April was notably dry and sunny. RAF Valley recorded just 29.8 mm of rainfall — only 55% of the long-term average of 54.4 mm. The local gauge at IBODOR6 (near Bodorgan) recorded 49.8 mm for the month, suggesting the reserve may have received somewhat more rain than the Valley station, though both confirm it was a drier than typical April.

Temperatures were mild, with daily highs reaching 14.4°C against a 12.1°C average. No air frost was recorded. But the headline figure is sunshine: 243.9 hours, far above the 172.9-hour average. Long sunny days and low rainfall are the perfect recipe for accelerating the spring drawdown — evapotranspiration is now running at full speed.

Rainfall dropped from 51.4 mm in March to 29.8 mm in April. The hydrological year cumulative (October to April) stands at 647 mm, still 119% of the long-term average (545 mm). Despite a dry April, the water banked underground during the wet winter remains substantial.

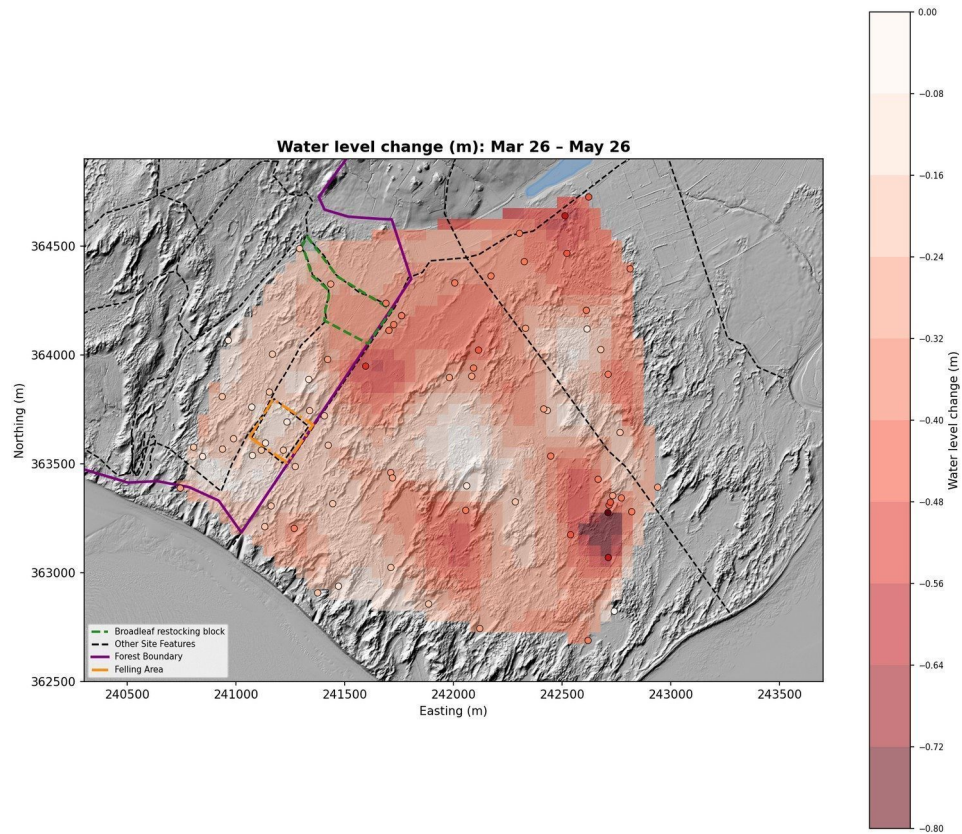
Local Water Levels

The well round on 2nd May 2026 covered 76 monitoring dipwells across the reserve. The picture is unambiguous: every single well is falling. Not one well showed a rise. The mean decline was -0.292 m, with the largest drops exceeding 0.7 m in the most responsive eastern wells.

The spring recession is now firmly established. With 243 hours of sunshine driving transpiration and only 30 mm of rain to replenish the aquifer, the water table has dropped substantially across the board. The forest wells (inside the purple boundary on the maps) are declining fastest — the Corsican pine canopy intercepts around a quarter of the rainfall and its deep roots draw water actively from the sand aquifer.

Month-on-Month Change: March – May 2026

The month-on-month map shows the spatial pattern of decline. The deepest drops (darkest red) are concentrated in the eastern and southeastern parts of the reserve, particularly around the T41 cluster and D38 where the aquifer is thinnest. The western block around the CEH wells is declining more moderately.



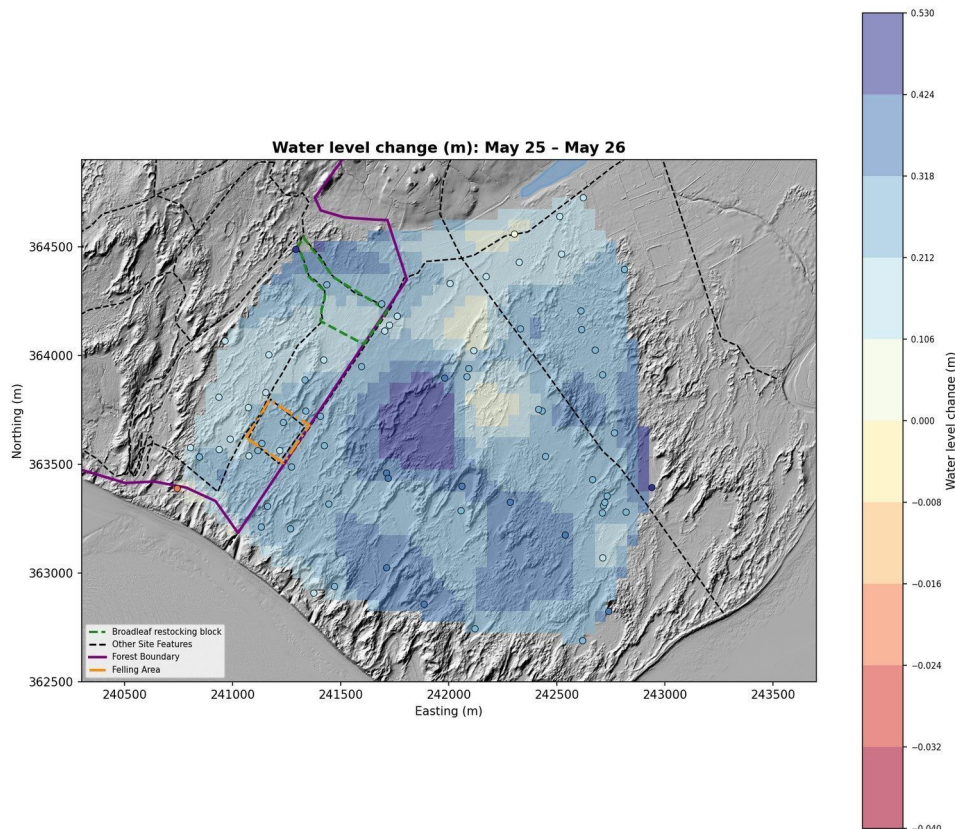
Water level change (m) from 30 Mar 2026 to 02 May 2026. All wells falling.

The five largest declines were: T41a (−0.750 m), D38 (−0.630 m), ceh25 (−0.590 m), ceh1 (−0.550 m), and ceh5 (−0.470 m). These are all in the fast-draining eastern aquifer where the sand is most permeable. At the other end, pe showed the smallest decline at just −0.050 m — this well sits close to the coast where the water table is buffered by sea level.

Year-on-Year: May 2025 vs May 2026

Despite the spring drawdown, water levels remain substantially higher than this time last year. Of 76 wells compared, 74 are still sitting higher than in May 2025, with a mean year-on-year rise of +0.243 m. The wet winter has given the aquifer a significant buffer.

Only two wells are at or below last year's level: D41 (unchanged) and ceh3 (−0.020 m) in the far west. The strongest year-on-year gains are at ceh24 (+0.510 m), ceh14 (+0.460 m), and nw5 (+0.410 m) — all in the central to southern parts of the reserve where the winter recharge had the greatest impact.

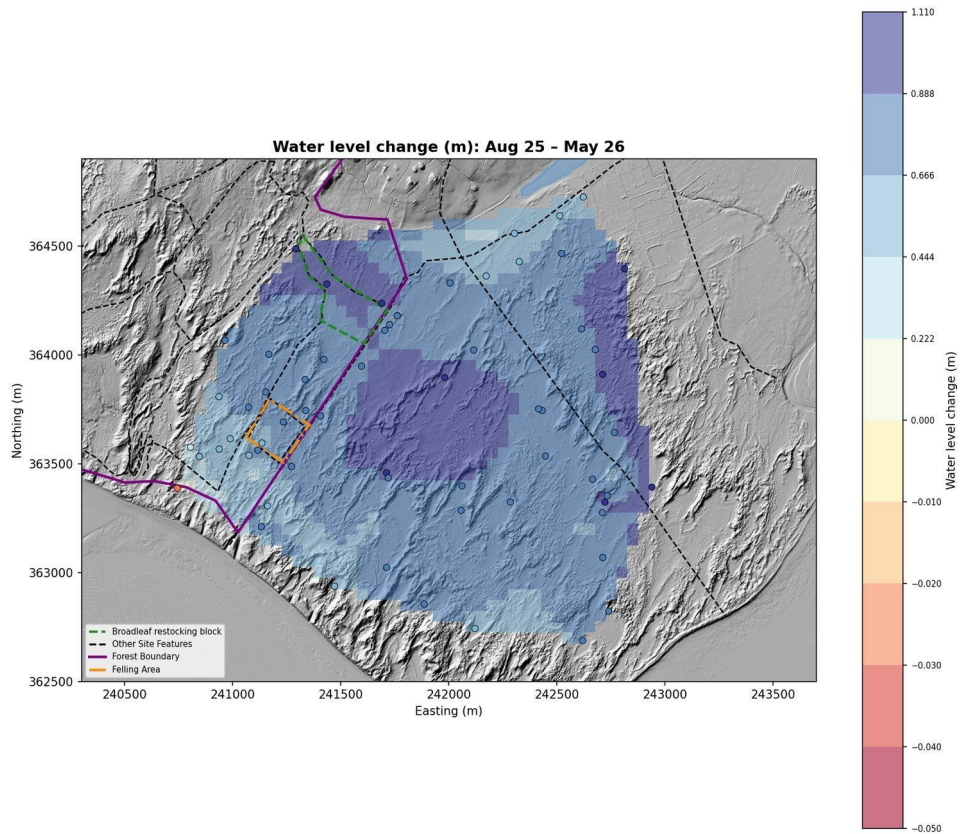


Year-on-year water level change from 10 May 2025 to 02 May 2026.

Rebound from Summer Low: August 2025 – May 2026

Since the summer low in August 2025, the net picture remains strongly positive. Across 63 wells with comparable data, the mean rise is +0.755 m (range −0.030 to +1.090 m). Only one well (ceh3) has dipped below its summer baseline — this is an outlier in the far west that appears to be influenced by a different hydrological regime.

The cumulative map shows the northern and central slacks retaining the most recharge, with the strongest rises exceeding 1 m around the ceh14, ceh24, and D15 wells. These are the deepest dune slacks where the water table is most responsive to seasonal recharge.



Cumulative water level change since 31 Aug 2025.

Outlook

The spring recession will continue to accelerate through May and June as evapotranspiration peaks. If dry conditions persist, we can expect another 0.2–0.4 m of decline by the next well round. The key question is whether any Atlantic fronts bring meaningful recharge to slow the drawdown.

The good news for the reserve's ecology is that the water table entered the drying season from a very high starting point. The dune slack pools should hold water longer than in a typical year, giving natterjack toad tadpoles a better window for development. The forest wells will continue to decline faster than the open dune wells due to canopy interception and root uptake — a pattern that underscores the hydrological case for the ongoing clearfell programme.